

Sustainability Isn't Optional



Sustainability has moved beyond buzzwords and boardroom pledges, with India Inc. proving it with action. For three consecutive years, *Business Today* has spotlighted sustainability efforts in corporate India. But 2025 marks a turning point. This year, for the first time, we have released an entire edition dedicated exclusively to sustainability, accompanied by a flagship event that celebrates those leading the charge.

At the heart of this effort is the *BT* India's Most Sustainable Companies 2025 initiative, an effort to recognise companies that have demonstrated exemplary commitment to Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) principles. These are businesses that are not merely complying with regulatory mandates but are embedding sustainability into the very core of their strategies.

The evaluation process for the awards was rigorous and transparent. CareEdge ESG Ratings, the knowledge partner, led the shortlisting based on publicly available data, evaluating companies from the top 1,000 listed entities across 11 sectors with significant environmental and social impact. A distinguished jury chaired by Rajnish Kumar, former Chairman of State Bank of India, lent credibility and depth to the final selection.

As you turn the pages of this edition, you will discover India's most sustainable companies. These include 11 sector-specific winners and four special recognitions. For industries that are hard to decarbonise—like oil and gas, power generation, metals and mining, and cement—two standout awards have been presented: the Transition Leader of the Year for leadership in net-zero pathways and the Climate Leadership Award, based on performance in emissions, water, and waste management. In financial services, sustainability champions were honoured across categories like Small Finance Banks, Non-Banking Finance Companies (NBFCs), Upper Layer NBFCs, and the Most Sustainable Bank.

There was a special award for Best Disclosures & Transparency Leader of the Year spanning all sectors. Another unique distinction—the Special Jury Award for Sustainability Leadership—was given for holistic and impactful leadership in ESG. What is clear is that Indian conglomerates are no longer viewing climate risk and social responsibility as peripheral concerns. As *Richa Sharma* and *Krishna Gopalan* observe, major business groups like the Tatas, the Aditya Birla Group, and Reliance Industries are making serious investments in clean energy and resilient infrastructure.

Firms are now integrating sustainability into strategic planning, risk frameworks, and capital allocation, making it clear that sustainability is synonymous with business continuity and competitiveness. The stakes are high. Extreme weather events are disrupting operations, and even the RBI has flagged climate change as a systemic financial risk.

These awards are not just about recognition, they seek to showcase a shift in mindset across India Inc, and a call to action for Indian businesses: sustainability is no longer optional. It is the foundation for growth, resilience, and long-term profitability. **BT**

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